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Review

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done enough translating himself and has included too many antiquated translations by others, even where newer ones exist. For example, ten selections come from S. R. Maitland's *Facts and Documents* of 1832, two are taken from a St. Bernard translation of 1889, and a chunk of Abelard's *Calamities* comes from a translation of 1922. The result is not only a proliferation of "forsooths" and "mayhaps," but some inaccuracies which could have been avoided by consultation of modern critical editions of the Latin originals. Nor does Peters intervene in his borrowed translations to regularize spellings or identify biblical and patristic quotations (in some cases he even deletes identifications that had earlier been provided). Since Wakefield and Evans offer twelve of the same texts that Peters does, but in more fluent, reliable, or better annotated form, the scrupulous student would do well to have both volumes at hand and use Wakefield when there is a choice.

ROBERT E. LERNER

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*Visions of the End. Apocalyptic Traditions in the Middle Ages.* By Bernard McGinn. [Number XCVI of the Records of Civilization: Sources and Studies.] (New York: Columbia University Press. 1979. Pp. xix, 377. \$25.00.)

The study of prophecy has been so important in past times that men of unusual prominence, learning, and influence felt it necessary to be expositors. Their lives and teachings helped shape events in their own times and influence later generations. Expositors have been traditionally churchmen, statesmen, historians, teachers, physicians, scientists, mathematicians, philosophers, and adventurers. Because such a cross-section of the intellectual community concerned themselves with this subject, prophetic studies have had a vital influence on the basic concepts of mankind, and expositors of prophecy have been active in nearly every major epoch. The Judaic-Christian idea that history has a beginning and an end, that God has a plan for history, and that His will is to be worked out in time in a prescribed way, has dominated Western culture since the beginning of the Christian era.

Dr. McGinn, in his new book, makes available selected translations, and commentary about the translations, from significant apocalyptic writings from the pre-Christian era to the fifteenth century. This book is a response to great need as no comprehensive introduction has ever appeared in English on this subject. Other similar products are either limited in scope or they are directed at sectarian interests where direct knowledge of the sources has not been important.

The author spends a lengthy introduction speculating on the origins of Judaic-Christian apocalyptic thought, and on the definition and distinction of basic principles of eschatology, apocalypticism, messianism, millenarianism, and related ideas. The remainder of the book is thematic within a chronological framework between 400 A.D. and 1500 A.D. Within this time frame, Dr. McGinn presents

the Latin and Greek apocalyptic writers and traditions, apocalypticism and the major crises of Church and state, and summaries of some seventy-five primary sources from the Tiburtine Sibyl through such as Beatus of Liebana, Joachim of Fiore, to Savonarola and Christopher Columbus.

Dr. McGinn's volume is both needed and useful as a book for the general reader interested in apocalyptic thought and as a text for classes concerned with medieval apocalypticism and views of history. As with any book which attempts such a wide scope of history, it is inconsistent in substance and detail. Several sections are nothing more than thumbnail sketches of an author plus a short translation excerpted from that writer's major work. On such occasions, one searches in vain for some interpretive thesis or argument. It seems a mixed bag, for example, to string one after the other short translations with little commentary from the Pseudo-Methodius, Beatus of Liebana, the poem "Muspilli," and Adso. Most noticeably, the book lacks any illustrations. Many of the expositors and writers Dr. McGinn presents could not resist depicting the imagery of the Apocalypse. Consequently, visual representation was integral to their thought.

Despite these reservations, students of medieval apocalyptic thought will find that Dr. McGinn has made an important contribution to the field in this volume. The translations will undoubtedly be a great help in the classroom where student proficiency in Latin is limited. The best parts of the book are the introduction (one of the clearest on the subject this writer has read) and the whole of Part Two, A.D. 1200-1500. Dr. McGinn has an excellent ability to make good generalizations; he is a well-known scholar in the field, and he writes well. The book has abundant notes and an extensive bibliography.

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*Castel S. Angelo e Borgo tra Roma e Papato.* By Cesare D'Onofrio. [Studi e testi per la storia della città di Roma, Vol. I.] (Rome: Romana Società Editrice. 1978. Pp. 350. Lire 10.000.)

*La papessa Giovanna. Roma e papato tra storia e leggenda.* By Cesare D'Onofrio. [Studi e testi per la storia della città di Roma, Vol. II.] (Rome: Romana Società Editrice. 1979. Pp. 286. Lire 12.500.)

These two volumes inaugurate a new series devoted to discrete, and, it might be said, unpredictable topics connected with the history of the city of Rome. Since a third volume has been announced, to be a study of Bernini and also to be authored by Cesare D'Onofrio, it is reasonable to regard this series as a vehicle for his work, indeed as the successor vehicle to the Staderini series that included his *Villa Aldobrandini* (1963), *Scalinate di Roma* (1973), and *Acque e fontane di Roma* (1977).